



HALL OF FAME: The Prithvi Theatres team in 1958; (left to right, encircled) Jennifer Kendall, Prithviraj Kapoor, Shashi Kapoor



PRITHVI THEATRES, MUMBAI

WHERE THE LIGHTS ARE NEVER SWITCHED OFF

What makes a modest 200-seater auditorium in suburban Mumbai the most respected theatre institution in the country? It's a question that has no answer except that it was fired by the dream of one woman named Jennifer Kendall, the daughter of one acting dynasty, married into another, who thought the time had come for theatre to receive the encouragement it needed from within the community rather than from apathetic bureaucrats. Veteran theatre director Dinesh Thakur of Ank recalls that when he directed Badal Sircar's *Baki Itihas* (1978), the play opened to just four viewers. In less than two years, Prithvi had made a name for itself and soon shows ran houseful. Unlike other institutions that crumble after the death of their founders, Prithvi has continued to flourish. Kendall had desired that "the lights at Prithvi must not be

switched off" when she died. After her death in 1984, her son Kunal Kapoor along with theatre director Feroze Khan continued to keep it going. In 1990, her daughter Sanjna Kapoor came on board. Her tenure has seen Prithvi expand its horizons by bringing international productions to India and making an effort to create the India Theatres Forum—an institution that will address issues relating to theatre in India. Sanjna started with a five-point agenda of setting up a children's wing with workshops and productions that culminated in an annual festival, "Our aim is to introduce children to theatre and create an audience for tomorrow." The past few years have seen the Prithvi Theatres festival emerge as the high point in the cultural map of India, with stalwarts like Habib Tanvir being showcased at the festival. The legacy of Prithviraj Kapoor, it seems, is in safe hands.

by **Nirmala Ravindran**

"In an ever-changing world, our effort has been to show that theatre matters."

SANJNA KAPOOR, DIRECTOR, PRITHVI THEATRES

STEP BY STEP *Shakuntala* (1944), based on Kalidas's classic mythological love-story between Dushyant and Shakuntala, was the first production of Prithvi Theatres. The stage performance beat its movie version hands down.

EXTRAORDINARY LEAGUE

When actor Zohra Segal asked Prithviraj why he named his company Prithvi Theatres in the plural, he replied it was his dream to have theatres in every town.

THE LIFE FORCE Prithvi Theatres has also brought international productions like *Theatre du Complicite* and *Footsbarn* to India. Prithviraj Kapoor's granddaughter, Sanjna, has been the force behind the India Theatres Forum that will bring together practitioners from all over India.